

Reality Shows

Outrageous shows on mainstream channels feature sexually loaded comments, even nudity. Take Nigar Khan bathing in a bikini on *Iss Jungle Se Mujhe Bachao* and Raju Srivastava being stripped on *Bigg Boss 3*.



Youth Channels

Dadagiri, a reality show on UTV Bindass features ritual humiliation for tasks not done and two abusive hosts, Vishal and Sonali, whose stock dialogues are: **VISHAL** Saale, ch****, *Zyada bolega to thok ke rakh doonga*.

SONALI You bloody b****, you don't know how to talk to your mistress?



teaching your boys how to treat women when they grow up—with disrespect. The Grand Theft Auto Vice City Stories video game can reward crimes with virtual money. Yes, they are learning crime pays. The reality shows on MTV and UTV Bindass have hosts who urge contestants to use any means possible to win, all the while addressing them as *saala* or bitch. Yes, they're teaching them the socialisation process, that life is tough. And on Facebook, they are learning to test their *kamina-pan*. Yes, they are learning to be ultra-competitive.

Call it technological addiction or parental absence, but urban Indian children are growing up in a world of constant mood elevators. Crowded out of playgrounds and pressured for time by school schedules, children are seeking fantasy worlds on the Net and in video games. This in a world where Bollywood has long done away with its Doordarshan code and is making U-rated movies on homosexuality and tv news has decided to let it all hang out. So children can watch *Dostana* to understand what a gigolo is and tune into primetime news bulletins to see a well-known comic Raju Srivastava being stripped in a reality show, *Bigg Boss 3*. It's an intensely wired universe that is producing children like Ritwaik Kapoor, a Standard VII student of a public school in Lucknow. He lives in a multi-storeyed apartment in the trans-Gomati area with no place to play. He rides his bicycle

in the compound for a while and when he gets bored, he sits on his father's computer to play video games such as The Guy Game, the English clone of *Kaun Banega Crorepati*, where a girl strips bit by bit as the prize for the correct answer. Ask him why he does so and Ritwaik says it's no worse than what's on TV.

Or take Mayank Rao, a nine-year-old in Standard IV in Bangalore. He has no friends—well except for two, his domestic's 10-year-old son and his 11-year-old cousin. It wasn't always like this. His parents, Reema and Vinay, say he used to play with the children in the building until they gifted him a computer for his eighth birthday. He took to it like a natural. While he does play games and surfs the Net, his favourites are the social networking sites where he registers as an 18-year-old (13 is the minimum age). He first got hooked to Orkut, then Facebook, where he plays games, takes quizzes, and chats with his 312 virtual friends. A wor-

ried lot, his parents have been trying to get him to go out and play or socialise. "But all my friends are online. I prefer chatting with them than playing," he says. He eats well, sleeps on time and does reasonably well in school but his mother has started regulating his Internet time to an hour. "Instead of talking to me he writes on my wall. I see messages like, 'Mom can I get hot chocolate instead of Complian'," says his bewildered mother. It's what sociologist Sanjay Srivastava calls the closing in of the social space. "Globalisation has created gated communities in the virtual and real sense. Children are chatting on the Net with the children they go to school with. They are choosing to live in an increasingly homogenised atmosphere. Their sense of engagement with the outside world is being restricted."

So even as children are

